

Under Performing ALLIANCE

In an extraordinary first year of ups and downs in UPA II, we present a list of the best and the worst performing ministers of the Union Council.

One Congress chief minister, asked for his rating of the UPA II, was uncharacteristically eloquent in declaring: "A year is a small slice of history, and governance is a journey." There may be some truth in his political homily but since his own state government's performance is under criticism, it is subject to discount. In today's coalition politics, a year is a long time. This is the Manmohan Singh-led UPA Government's second innings and, like organisations, a government is only as good as the sum of its parts. In the case of UPA II, those parts add up to 77, the number of Union ministers. That is the consequence of coalition pressures. Like in its earlier avatar, the ministerial make-up also demands a balance between regional, caste and factions, which also translates into administrative flab. More than the prime minister, it is regional chieftains who decide which of their MPs occupies a ministerial berth. Given power and responsibility, some rise admirably to the challenge, others fail but it somehow seems to balance out. INDIA TODAY's assessment and ranking of UPA ministers is a judicious mix of perception and reality. The dictionary defines perception as being based on insight, intuition, or knowledge gained by perceiving. Our senior editors and correspondents interact with ministers and senior bureaucrats on a regular basis and write frequently about policy, performance and personalities. It allows us to deliver a fairly accurate assessment and ranking of Manmohan's Council of Ministers. Here it is.

THE BIG MINISTRIES

P. CHIDAMBARAM

Minister of Home Affairs

The Lone Ranger

For 15 months after 26/11, there was peace. Then Pune happened and things have suddenly come apart for Chidambaram, arguably the most talked and written about Union minister. Since then, the spate of Maoist attacks have taken the sheen off his tenure and Mr Tough is increasingly coming under criticism from within his own party. But Chidambaram continues in the path that he believes is right.

Big Flop

He released his fax number and asked Maoists to get in touch with him. The Maoists used it to play the propaganda game.

Achievement

■ An incident-free 2009 saw even the BJP giving him the thumbs up. Gujarat Chief Minister Narendra Modi said, under Chidambaram, states were getting positive and quick response from the Centre.

Failure

■ Seen to have failed to carry his party with him on his strategy. The resulting confusing signals emanating from the Government about the need to take the development approach have blunted his strategy against the Maoists.

▼ 65%

